

The Renovation Money Checklist

15 hidden costs to check in every quote, the payment rules that protect you, and the documents you must keep — on 5 printable pages.

15

hidden costs

10–15%

contingency

10

documents

How to use it: print it, take it to every contractor meeting, and tick the boxes. If an item is not clearly in the quote, ask the question next to it — and get the answer in writing.

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1 · 15 hidden costs to check in every quote

Most budget overruns don't come from one big disaster — they come from small items nobody put in the quote. Compare quotes only after you have asked all 15 questions.

Cost	Ask the contractor
☐ Demolition & strip-out	Is removing the old kitchen / tiles / floors included?
☐ Waste disposal & skips	Who pays for skips and tip fees — and how many are included?
☐ Delivery, crane or lift	Are delivery, carrying upstairs and crane hire in the price?
☐ Permits & fees	Who applies for permits and pays the fees?
☐ Architect / engineer	Do you need structural calculations or drawings — and who pays?
☐ Protection & daily cleaning	Are floors, stairs and furniture protected? Final clean included?
☐ Electrical upgrades	Does the new kitchen or heat pump need a bigger fuse box or new circuits?
☐ Plumbing re-routing	What if pipes must be moved? Fixed price or hourly?
☐ Unexpected finds	What happens with asbestos, rot or damp — rates agreed up front?
☐ Finishing	Skirting, sealing, silicone, painting touch-ups — included or “extra”?
☐ Fixtures & fittings	Taps, sockets, switches, handles: which models, and who supplies them?
☐ Tax / VAT	Is the price including tax? Which rate applies to your job?
☐ Temporary living	Kitchen or bathroom out of use: temporary setup, storage, moving costs?
☐ Price increases	Are material prices fixed, and for how long is the quote valid?
☐ Contingency	Have YOU kept 10–15% aside for all of the above?

Rule: for every “not included” or “unclear” answer, write down your own estimate and add it to that quote. The quote with the lowest *sticker* price is often not the one with the lowest *true* cost.

2 · How much contingency?

10–15%

of your total budget, kept aside for surprises. Older house, structural work or unknown wiring? Plan closer to 15–20%.

- ☐ Working budget = total budget – contingency
- ☐ Contingency is for surprises, not for upgrades
- ☐ Check how much you have used every week
- ☐ Above 75% used? Stop all optional changes

3 · Pay for work done — never ahead of it

Your payments are your leverage. Tie every payment to a visible milestone, and compare what you have paid with how much of the work is really finished.

% paid to a contractor $\leq$ % of their work that is finished

- ☐ Keep the deposit modest and linked to a clear start or material order
- ☐ Every payment is linked to a milestone you can check on site
- ☐ Update “% work done” per contractor every week
- ☐ Hold back the final payment (e.g. 5–10%) until the list below is complete

Before the final payment

- ☐ Every punch-list item is fixed (walk through room by room)
- ☐ Final inspection passed and certificates received
- ☐ Warranty and manuals handed over in writing
- ☐ Invoices match contract + approved change orders — nothing more
- ☐ Site cleared and cleaned, waste removed
- ☐ Keys, codes and spare materials handed over

4 · 10 documents to keep

- ☐ Signed contract per contractor (scope, price, dates, payment schedule)
- ☐ The quote the contract is based on
- ☐ Liability insurance certificate of every contractor
- ☐ Permits, approvals and plans / drawings
- ☐ Every change order — in writing, with price and extra days
- ☐ All invoices and proof of payment
- ☐ Receipts for materials you bought yourself
- ☐ Inspection reports (electrical, gas, structural...)
- ☐ Warranties and manuals of installed equipment
- ☐ Photos at every stage — especially behind walls before they are closed

Tip: one folder per contractor in your cloud drive, and one “Photos” folder per room with sub-folders Before · Demolition · Rough-in · Walls · Finishing · Final.

5 · Order materials on time

Late tiles, taps or appliances are one of the most common causes of delay — the installer is ready, the material isn't. Work backwards from the day it will be installed:

Order-by date = install date – supplier lead time – safety buffer (± 5 days)

Decide-by date = order-by date – 1 week

Example: kitchen installed on 2 July, worktop lead time 3 weeks → order by 6 June → decide by 30 May.

6 · The 10-minute Monday routine

- ☐ What is overdue? (payments, decisions, orders, follow-ups)
- ☐ What must be decided or ordered this week?
- ☐ Which payments are due — and is the work really done?
- ☐ Is any task late that other tasks depend on?
- ☐ Forecast final cost vs budget — still OK?

Coming soon: Renovation OS — the Excel planner that does all of this for you. It checks hidden costs in quotes, warns you when you pay ahead of the work, calculates order-by dates and ranks your to-dos every Monday. You're on the list — you'll get the launch discount on launch day.

YOUR NEXT ACTIONS — ranked by urgency

 33 ACTIONS NEED YOUR ATTENTION					
#	Priority	What to do	Where	Due	When
1	Urgent	Decision overdue: Living room flooring	Selections & Orders	23 May 2026	23 days overdue
2	Urgent	Late task: Plumbing rough-in — FlowRight Plumbing	Timeline	05 Jun 2026	10 days overdue
3	Urgent	Should have started: Heat pump & ventilation — ClimaHeat HVAC	Timeline	06 Jun 2026	9 days overdue
4	Urgent	Overdue payment: FlowRight Plumbing — Rough-in complete 40% (€ 3,680)	Payments	10 Jun 2026	5 days overdue
5	Urgent	Follow up with Bright Spark Electric: Asked for revised schedule after 1-week slip — no reply yet	Contractors	10 Jun 2026	5 days overdue
6	Urgent	Issue action due: Socket positions don't match kitchen plan → Send marked-up plan to electrician	Issues & Punch List	11 Jun 2026	4 days overdue
7	Urgent	Decide on change order CO-5: EV charger + 6 extra circuits (+€ 3,400)	Change Orders	12 Jun 2026	3 days overdue
8	Urgent	High-severity issue: Rotten joist found under living room floor → Engineer to confirm repair method	Issues & Punch List	12 Jun 2026	3 days overdue
9	Urgent	Order late — install at risk: Sink & tap	Selections & Orders	13 Jun 2026	2 days overdue
10	Urgent	Decision overdue: Bathroom 2 tiles	Selections & Orders	14 Jun 2026	1 day overdue

+ 23 more — see *This Week* and in each tab.